

Chicago Tribune



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SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 15, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Migrants urged to keep court dates

Despite fears and risks, Chicago advocates say ‘it could be more devastating if they don’t go’

By Nell Salzman and Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

Briseida de la Cruz Morales cried when she left her family’s Waukegan home for immigration court Thursday morning and said goodbye to her husband for what she believed would be the last time.

The 37-year-old from Mexico

was scared to attend her Chicago court hearing, part of the process for people seeking asylum, or a form of protection granted to foreign nationals living in the United States and unable to return to their country due to past persecution or a fear of being persecuted in the future. Morales was worried that President Donald Trump’s policy changes around immigration could mean she would get

deported Thursday.

But the family’s pastor in Waukegan encouraged her to go to court, assuring her she had a strong asylum case and would be at greater risk of deportation if she skipped the hearing. After weeks of build-up and hours of crying, she went to her hearing. And she left with a new court date for 2028 — not a deportation order.

“There are hundreds of people (in Waukegan) who don’t want to go to their court appointments out

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Briseida de la Cruz Morales, center, with her children Edith and Christian Sanchez de la Cruz after eating at Three Happiness restaurant in Chicago’s Chinatown on Thursday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“We are hardworking, honest people ... fleeing from our country. We are not criminals, we haven’t harmed anyone, and we are here asking for a second chance.” — Briseida de la Cruz Morales, who came to Waukegan to escape cartels in Mexico



‘NO PIG LEFT BEHIND’

Meet the Chicagoland volunteers racing to rescue and rehome swine across the Midwest

By Carolyn Stein | Chicago Tribune

April Noga had two days to prepare for this rescue mission — save 18 pigs from a petting zoo in northeastern Illinois.

The 36-year-old had a pet pig of her own and had rescued pigs before, but she had never done a rescue mission of this scale.

“I was like, ‘OK, if I’m gonna work on this case, no pigs left behind. I’m going to somehow figure out how to do this all and get all these pigs out,’” Noga said. “I didn’t sleep, didn’t eat...all I was doing was networking and hopping online and practically asking the pig community for help.”

With little time to spare, Noga and a few others headed toward the petting zoo in June 2020, having rented a moving van to help transport all 18 pigs. As the rescuers spent hours rounding up pigs in the blazing hot sun, Noga noticed an extra seven pigs on the property she had not been told about. Without hesitation, she eventually returned to the petting zoo to save them.

She later found out those extra seven were pregnant, bringing the total number of pigs she rescued up to 42.

Since then, Noga has traveled thousands of miles to rescue and rehome pigs all over the Midwest and beyond. In the summer of 2020, Noga and her husband started Chicagoland Pig Rescue, the only nonprofit in the Chicago area dedicated to rescuing, fostering and transporting pigs across state lines. The organization, funded primarily by donations, has saved over 300 pigs through its network of foster partnerships throughout the Midwest.

“There’s not as many sanctuaries as there needs to be to meet the need,” said Phoebe Conner, co-director of Chicagoland Pig Rescue. “But there are sanctuaries — farm animal sanctuaries — in every single state and I think a lot of people don’t even realize that.”

Illinois has about 20 farm animal sanctuaries, according to Conner. They will usually take

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April Noga, above, and her husband run Chicagoland Pig Rescue at their home in the south suburbs. The couple used to have furniture throughout the room, but the pigs tore it apart. “They destroyed the last three sets, so when they tore through the last one we were like, ‘What would you do?’” Noga said. “Imagine a 3-year-old toddler that has hulk strength,” said her husband, Tyler Tassone. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Madigan’s pension on hold after conviction

Former speaker had received \$158K per year from the state

By Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Former Democratic House Speaker Michael Madigan’s \$158,000 annual state of Illinois pension is being halted following his high-profile corruption conviction.

Timothy Blair, executive secretary of the Illinois General Assembly Retirement System, said Thursday he “sent the letter out today” to notify Madigan the pension system will stop sending his monthly checks because Illinois law bars elected officials in the legislative pension plan from collecting payments once they are convicted or enter a guilty plea in a felony tied to their government job.

But Blair said Madigan will receive his nearly \$13,170 pension check for February because that has already been processed.

In a felony case that rocked Illinois politics, a federal jury on Wednesday convicted Madigan on 10 of 23 counts, including bribery conspiracy and other corruption charges focused heavily on a Commonwealth Edison bribery scandal and his plot to get a state board appointment for alderman-turned-government-mole Danny Solis.

The jury deadlocked on several counts — including the marquee racketeering conspiracy charge that accused Madigan and co-defendant Michael McClain of running Madigan’s operations like a criminal enterprise — and acquitted Madigan on several others. Prosecutors have yet to decide if they will retry Madigan on the deadlocked charges.

A sentencing date for the 82-year-old Madigan, of Chicago’s Southwest Side, has yet to be set.

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INSIDE

Watchdog to audit DOGE data access

The Treasury Department’s Office of Inspector General said Friday that it is launching an audit of the security controls for the federal government’s payment system, after Democratic senators raised red flags about the access provided to Trump aide Elon Musk’s Department of Government Efficiency team.

Nation & World

6 years on, legal battle persists for those in Aurora mass shooting

By Molly Morrow
Aurora Beacon-News

Diana Juarez, 38, likes to tell stories about her father with her mother, her siblings and her own children. About how he loved to work on cars, how he would wear

matching Cubs or Bears jerseys with his family when there were games going on, the little jokes and sayings he repeated to them.

Juarez was close with her father, Vicente. She’s a teaching assistant in Oswego, and lives in the house Vicente lived in, along

with her kids, her mother and her younger brother.

“I had just texted my mom on Monday to tell her, like, I thank God every day for her being my mom and for her choosing my dad as my dad,” Juarez told The Beacon-News.

This time of year is particularly difficult, as the anniversary of Vicente’s death approaches. Juarez was one of five people killed in the Feb. 15, 2019, mass shooting at the Henry Pratt Co. in Aurora.

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TODAY’S WEATHER



High 34 Low 25

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 10

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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